end their lives by collapsing down to a fabulously dense object from which nothing, not even light, can escape. The notion of these “collapsed stars,” as they were known then, generated intense debate. The forbidding mathematical edifice of general relativity, along with the computational intensity and unusual (at the time) tools required for the Oppenheimer-Volkoff calculation—not to mention the sheer strangeness of their result—made it difficult for other physicists to take the idea of collapsed stars seriously.

This mathematical complexity also made it hard for Einstein to understand the implications of his own theory. “Together with a young collaborator, I arrived at the interesting result that gravitational waves do not exist,” Einstein wrote to his old friend Max Born in 1936. Gravitational waves—ripples in spacetime, formed by colliding hyperdense stars and similarly intense events, racing out at the speed of light from their violent births—were a unique prediction of general relativity, not found in Newton’s theory of gravity. But the strange mathematics of the new theory led Einstein and his collaborator Rosen astray. They published a paper claiming to prove that gravitational waves aren’t physical objects and are merely mathematical fictions of the theory. Einstein was later set straight by the American physicist Howard Percy Robertson, but Rosen remained unconvinced that gravitational waves were real, and his paper with Einstein was never retracted, leading to a great deal of confusion about the reality of one of the fundamental predictions of general relativity, a confusion that persisted for decades.

The mathematical difficulty of the theory, the confusing arguments surrounding its predictions, and the remoteness of its predictions from the realm of experiment left general relativity off to the side as physics boomed after World War II. The new sources of scientific funding that flowed from the military-industrial complex largely ignored general relativity. But, in the late 1950s, the field slowly began to blossom. Several conferences were held on the subject, and a professional community of relativistic astrophysicists and cosmologists began to form. One of the most important of these conferences was the 1957 Chapel Hill conference, organized by Bryce DeWitt and Cécile DeWitt-Morette, a talented physicist who had studied with de Broglie in France (and who was married to Bryce DeWitt).

A variety of physics luminaries descended on Chapel Hill for the